

Year	Whiting Corp.		Willcox & Gibbs	
	Earned Per Share ^a	Price Range	Earned Per Share	Price Range
1970	\$1.81	22½-16¼	\$.34	18½-4½
1969	2.63	37-17¼	.05	20½-8¾
1968	3.63	43½-28¾	.35	20½-8½
1967	3.01	36½-25	.47	11-4¾
1966	2.49	30¼-19¼	.41	8-3¾
1965	1.90	20-18	.32	10½-6½
1964	1.53	14-8	.20	9½-4½
1963	.88	15-9	.13	14-4¾
1962	.46	10-6½	.04	19¼-8¼
1961	.42	12½-7¼	.03	19½-10½

^a Year ended following April 30.

The history of the two companies throws an interesting light on the development of medium-sized businesses in this country, in contrast with much larger-sized companies that have mainly appeared in these pages. Whiting was incorporated in 1896, and thus goes back at least 75 years. It seems to have kept pretty faithfully to its materials-handling business and has done quite well with it over the decades. Willcox & Gibbs goes back even farther—to 1866—and was long known in its industry as a prominent maker of industrial sewing machines. During the past decade it adopted a policy of diversification in what seems a rather outlandish form. For on the one hand it has an extraordinarily large number of subsidiary companies (at least 24), making an astonishing variety of products, but on the other hand the entire conglomeration adds up to mighty small potatoes by usual Wall Street standards.

The earnings developments in Whiting are rather characteristic of our business concerns. The figures show steady and rather spectacular growth from 41 cents a share in 1960 to \$3.63 in 1968. But they carried no assurance that such growth must continue indefinitely. The subsequent decline to only \$1.77 for the 12 months ended January 1971 may have reflected nothing more than the slowing down of the general economy. But the stock price reacted in severe fashion, falling about 60% from its 1968 high (43½) to the close of 1969. Our analysis would indicate that the shares represented a sound and attractive secondary-issue investment—suitable for the enterprising investor as part of a group of such commitments.